EDITORIAL

Mehndi Ki Katar Mein Khada Bharat

From viral reels to miracles: a story of faith, algorithms and the helplessness of the common man.

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A mehndi that gets you married. A slip of paper that reads your mind. A shrine so crowded that breathing becomes difficult. This is India in 2026, and the story begins on your phone.

Ek Viral Video, Lakhon Ki Umeed

It is eleven at night. You are lying in bed, scrolling through reels. A video comes up: a queue stretching for miles, and a caption claiming that applying this mehndi gets unmarried people married soon.

You laugh and move on. But the next morning, the same video is doing the rounds in your family's WhatsApp group.

This is not an imaginary scene. On 13 September 2026, at the Moti Dungri Ganesh Temple in Jaipur, during Sinjara, exactly this happened. According to ThePrint, lakhs of people turned up for the mehndi prasad, the queues ran for miles, and a large part of MD Road and GLN Road was jammed. National Herald reports that the belief linking mehndi to marital blessings is old and local, but the claim of "guaranteed quick marriage" spread through a viral reel, and that is what produced this unprecedented crowd.

And this is not the only incident. The road to Uttarakhand's Kainchi Dham sits in traffic jams for hours. In Sehore, Madhya Pradesh, people have died at events distributing rudraksha. At Rajasthan's Khatu Shyam, one morning, the crowd that surged forward as the temple gate opened killed three women.

This article does not point a finger at anyone's faith. It asks only one question: **God has existed for centuries, and so have believers, so why this crowd, why suddenly, why now?**

Ek Reel Se Janasailab Tak

Earlier, the story of a temple miracle travelled by word of mouth. It stayed within a village, a town or a circle of relatives. Now the same story becomes a reel and reaches lakhs of phones in a single night.

Social media algorithms run less on whether a video is true or false and more on how much people are watching it, how long they stay on it and how much they share it. So a video making miraculous or emotional claims, if it manages to hold people, can reach lakhs. (Every platform's algorithm works differently, but this general tendency shows up everywhere.)

> **An algorithm does not verify miracles. It only notices how long you stayed.**

Then begins the game of crowd feeding crowd. When you see thousands of people heading to a place, a voice in your head says: so many people can't all be wrong, can they? The same logic spreads a movement or a protest from city to city. The psychology of a religious wave and a political wave is the same; only the flag differs.

Kainchi Dham is the latest example. Citing the district administration, ThePrint reported that in the first six months of 2026, 24.34 lakh people visited, three times the roughly eight lakh who used to come in an entire year. Nearly two-thirds of the visitors were between 15 and 30 years old. Around the same time the film "Hanuman Ansh", based on the life of Neem Karoli Baba, did well at the box office, and according to Business Today, more than 50,000 people reached the shrine in a single recent weekend. The administration is now considering a system of advance registration.

Bharat Ke Naye Dharmik Hotspots: Aapka Ilaka Kahan Hai?

Each region has developed its own model. In some places temples are at the centre, in others babas, in others a government scheme, and in others the claim of miraculous healing.

Region	Emerging model	Examples
Rajasthan	Temple circuit and viral wish-fulfilment	The Moti Dungri mehndi festival in Jaipur (2026), Khatu Shyam
Madhya Pradesh	Storyteller-centred shrines and mass events	Kubereshwar Dham (Sehore), Bageshwar Dham (Chhatarpur)
Uttar Pradesh	Baba-centred satsang networks	The Hathras satsang (2024)
Pilgrim towns of UP and MP	Government corridors and religious tourism	Kashi Vishwanath Corridor, Ujjain's Mahakal Lok, Ayodhya Ram Mandir
Uttarakhand	Shrines made famous by film and celebrity, young devotees	Kainchi Dham: 24.34 lakh visitors in the first six months of 2026
Punjab	Village-by-village churches and "healing" gatherings	India Today's 2022 cover story reported around 65,000 active pastors; the 2011 census put Christians at 1.26%, and the real number is debated
Nationwide (digital)	Online astrology, YouTube storytellers, reel-famous saints	Astrology apps, viral sermons

The reputation of tantra and black magic is an old one in places like Assam's Kamakhya. What is new is that such centres no longer take decades to form; they can emerge in a few years.

Look around you for a moment. Which shrine, baba or temple near your city suddenly became famous in the last five years? Perhaps it is part of this map too.

Darr, Deri Aur Darbar

Crowds are not built by devotion alone; they are built by anxiety too. Ask any one person in that queue why they are there. The answer will probably be: I can't get a job, my exam result is stuck, my daughter's marriage is delayed, the treatment is expensive, the debt keeps growing.

> **When the system gives no answer, a person goes where someone promises one.**

The slip of paper, the mehndi, the rudraksha and the amulet are all symbols of that instant solution. Between the long queue at a government hospital and the endless court dates, a baba's darbar looks like a cheap and quick way out.

Alongside this, roads, expressways and trains have improved, and the middle class has some money to spend. A pilgrimage is now also a weekend trip. Hotels, shops and taxi drivers earn more, so the whole region joins in the promotion. One visit by a politician or a celebrity pours ghee on this fire.

Kise Faayda, Kaun Uthata Hai Jokhim?

A small economy runs alongside the crowd: hotels and homestays, taxis, shops selling prasad and flowers. At Kainchi Dham, according to officials, people who arrive and then search for a place to stay add to the traffic and parking problems.

But the risk is not shared equally. Most of those who died in Hathras were women. In 2022 at Khatu Shyam, all three who died in the crush as the gate opened were women, with nearly a lakh people gathered outside the temple. In August 2025 at Kubereshwar Dham in Sehore, two women died in a stampede during the rudraksha distribution.

Three incidents are not statistics, but the question is worth asking: if the earnings are spread across many hands, whose life is lost in a stampede?

Aastha Nahin, Jawabdehi Ka Sawaal

Faith is every individual's private right, and whether God exists or not is not the question here. The question is about the arrangements that call lakhs of people to one place.

On 2 July 2024, 121 people died in a stampede after a satsang in Hathras. According to the FIR, permission had been given for only 80,000 people, but around 2.5 lakh had gathered. The judicial commission report, tabled in the Assembly in March 2025, held the organisers primarily responsible and pointed to negligence by the local administration and police. The commission cleared "Bhole Baba" of direct responsibility, and the victims' families reacted in mixed ways, with many expressing disappointment.

After the events of August 2025 in Sehore, the Madhya Pradesh Human Rights Commission sought a report from the collector and the SP, and the Chief Secretary summoned both officers. According to officials, seven deaths occurred during the event: two in the stampede, and the other five reported as linked to illness and the huge crowd.

So the question is not about faith but about arrangements and accountability. Organisers should take responsibility for crowd management. The administration should check crowd estimates and venue capacity before granting permission. And on claims of miracle cures, a law already exists: the Drugs and Magic Remedies (Objectionable Advertisements) Act of 1954 prohibits advertisements claiming to cure certain diseases through "magic remedies" such as amulets, mantras and kavachas. The real question is whether it is enforced.

Asli Qataarein Kab Chhoti Hongi?

God is the same, and so is faith. What has changed is the medium, the mobile phone. What has changed is the speed, the algorithm. And what has grown is the need, the anxiety of the common man. When these three meet, any place can become a new religious hub within a few years.

If society wants people to stand less often in queues for miracles, it will have to shorten the queues for jobs, healthcare and justice. As long as the system does not answer life's real difficulties, the mehndi queues will keep getting longer.

Aapke Shehar Mein Kaun-Sa Dham Viral Hai?

Next time a miracle reel lands on your phone, pause for a moment before you forward it and ask yourself: **is there faith behind this, or an algorithm?**

Tell us: which new shrine or baba has suddenly become the talk of your area?